

Over the Seven Seas

International travel involves clearing a lot of formalities and getting a lot of paperwork done (passports, visas, insurance, and so on). The good news is that you can do most of this online. Not entirely, of course, as you will still have to fill out forms, sign many times, and be physically present for visas of some countries. But you can look up visa requirements for all countries, download passport forms, check

the passport status online, look up foreign exchange rates, and consider insurance options. Once you've booked with a site, they'll send someone over with the various forms and take care of all the formalities. You save your breath and time. You can download forms and check passport status online at Passport.nic.in and get information on travel insurance at Hotclaim.com.



Watch the deals space in portals for special holidays or off-season hotel packages for Indian and international destinations.

Holiday packages

Prefer escorted tours? Take your pick from a wide range of escorted tours online. Research, compare Indian and international tours and get it all done online at www.thomascook.co.in or raj-travels.com. You can take care of all formalities like air tickets and related paper work at these sites or just buy the tour and get your ticket done elsewhere. Most portals have inbound and outbound group tours.

The Web offers same or better rates as a travel agent and most reputed sites are as reliable as regular travel agents. However, print out your vouchers and maintain records of all your transactions and phone numbers. If you ever happen to be in a soup, get online, and call. Most portals are pretty prompt in attending if you have a genuine problem. The trick to landing a good deal is hard work—it involves constant comparison with different portals as well as 'offline' travel agents. But in the end it pays off when you have those extra bucks to spend on your holiday shopping spree!

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offer. For example, at Traveljini, renting an Esteem for about 8 hours in Mumbai will cost you about Rs 1,200 onwards (driver's allowance and extra kilometres are charged additionally), while renting the same model for half a day through Travnova will cost you Rs 1,700 onwards.

International car rentals are fairly straightforward and done through the same CRS as the flight reservation through local offices of international car rental agencies like Hertz or Avis. The prices are in US dollars and you rarely find deals.



A place to rest

Booking a hotel is a breeze online, what with the wide variety and

range available right under our noses—ranging from five stars to budget hotels. Indiatimes (www.travel.indiatimes.com) has a database of hotels where you'll be able to find a hotel anywhere in India for under Rs 500 a night. If you're looking for a cheap hotel, you'll find it here.

You can also book budget hotels at www.indianbudgethotels.com. Traveljini has a database of hotels with tariffs starting from Rs 1,500 which you can book online. Travnova is great for a wide range of hotel packages including premium hotels.

International hotel bookings are taken care of by www.worldres.com or www.amadeus.net, where you can log on and book a room against your credit card.